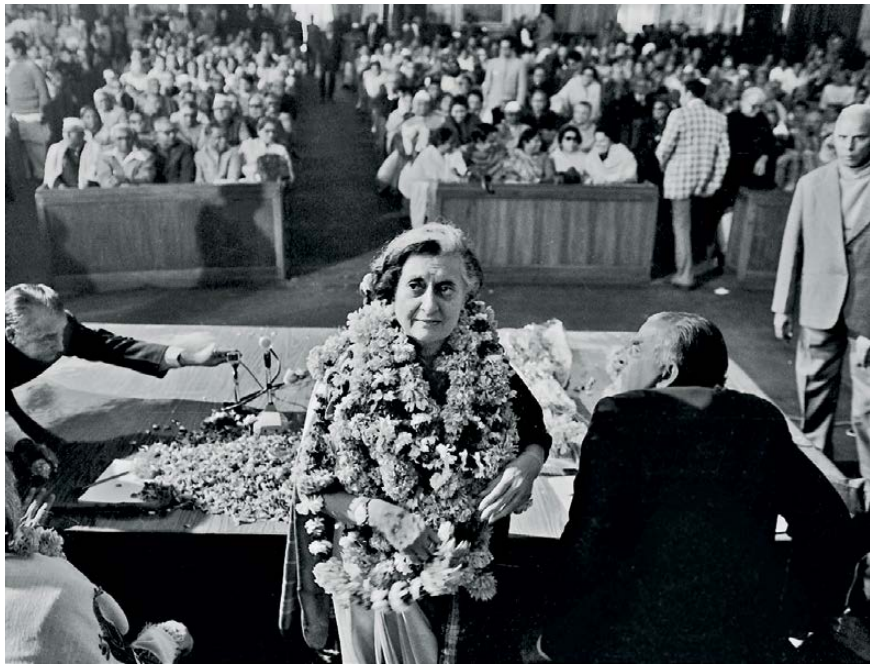
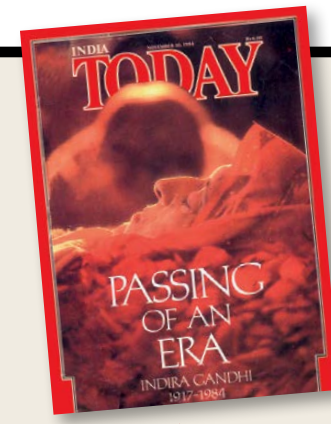
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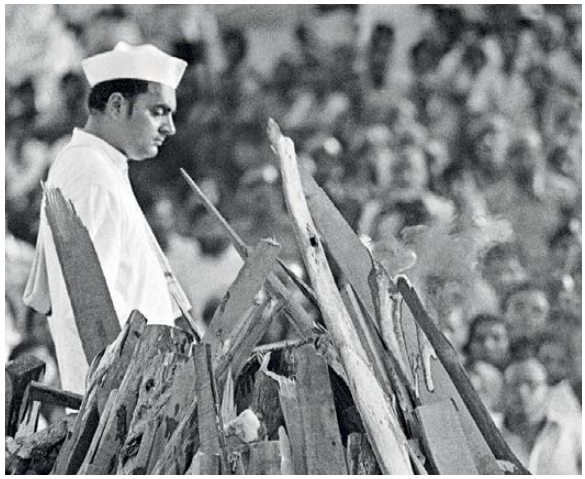




Passing of an Era
Nov. 30, 1984

"Fittingly, there were few tears, few expressions of genuine grief. It was as Indira Gandhi would have wanted it. Shock, disbelief, anger were the immediate reactions. But at the end was a terrible silence as the sheer enormity of the tragedy dawned."

INDIA TODAY ARCHIVES



RAGHU RAI



GANDHIAN SCENES Clockwise from left, Rajiv Gandhi at Sanjay Gandhi's funeral, June 1980; Indira Gandhi in Parliament, Jan. 1980 and Rajiv with Indira at a Congress meeting in Calcutta in 1983

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Mrs Gandhi would not live to see the end of the tempestuous decade that unfolded since her declaration of Emergency in 1975. Yet the close of this chapter bore the stamp of her personality as surely as its beginning. Which is remarkable, given that by March 1977, Mrs G was in a spiral of disgrace and defeat, her party reduced to 154 seats and relegated to the sidelines. Her return from that nadir was a dramatic, Humayun-esque comeback, and similarly destined to end in tragedy.

The first step on the long march back came early in July 1977—Mrs Gandhi's elephant-back ride to show solidarity with the Dalit victims of a caste massacre in Belchi, Bihar. As a photo op, it demonstrated her ability to wrongfoot her opponents. With patience and an awareness of the valence of her own public persona she seized the upper hand in the Janata government's 'witch hunt' (as her supporters painted it) seeking to jail her on charges related to the Emergency. Growing public sympathy for her and frustration at the ego wars of the Janata *netas* culminated in the piquant moment in 1979, when PM Charan Singh sought her support for his government. When he refused to drop the charges against her and her son Sanjay, she brought his government down—revenge served cold.

The national election, held in January 1980, erased the humiliations of the 1977 defeat for Mrs Gandhi: Congress(I) won a majority of 353 seats (more than the Janata's 1977 landslide of 295) while the rump of the Janata, now headed by Jagjivan Ram, was reduced to 31. But this final triumph as PM would be overshadowed by personal tragedy in the absurdly accidental death of Sanjay, and the carnage of Operation Bluestar, before its brutal denouement in her assassination and the gruesome anti-Sikh pogroms that followed, in the autumn of 1984. ■